



Acts 7:17-43

Jesus In: The Rejected Deliverer (Master)

Intro:

Last week, as Stephen continued his response to the religious leaders, we saw through the story of Joseph a pattern that ultimately pointed to Jesus: the one rejected by his own was the very one God used to save them. This week, Stephen continues to show the religious leaders how everything pointed to Christ now using the story of Moses. Through Moses, Stephen shows how God raised up a deliverer for His people, yet the very people he was sent to deliver rejected him and thrust him aside. And as the story unfolds, Stephen reveals the deeper problem behind their rejection: although God delivered them from their physical bondage in Egypt, their hearts remained bound to Egypt.

V.17-22 “

““But as **the time of the promise drew near**, which God had granted to Abraham, the **people increased and multiplied in Egypt** until there arose over Egypt **another king who did not know Joseph**. He **dealt shrewdly with our race** and forced our fathers to expose their infants, so that they would not be kept alive. At this time Moses was born; and **he was beautiful in God’s sight**. And he was brought up for **three months in his father’s house**, and when he was exposed, **Pharaoh’s daughter adopted him** and brought him up as her own son. And **Moses was instructed in all the wisdom of the Egyptians**, and he was **mighty in his words and deeds**.”

1. Bondage IN Egypt

Stephen picks up the story several generations after Joseph. Just as God had promised Abraham, the people of Israel had multiplied greatly in Egypt, but their circumstances had completely changed. A new Pharaoh had risen who did not know Joseph, and instead of receiving favor in Egypt, *God’s people were now enslaved and oppressed by Egypt*. Their bondage became so severe that Pharaoh even ordered their children to be killed.

Yet notice how Stephen begins: “the time of the promise drew near.” Their circumstances may have looked like God’s promise was failing, but God was still accomplishing exactly what He had promised. The people had multiplied, and even in their bondage, God was already preparing the means through which He would deliver them.

Verse 20 introduces Moses: “*At this time Moses was born.*” While Pharaoh was trying to destroy Israel, God was preserving Israel’s future deliverer. Moses was preserved for three months in his father’s house, adopted by Pharaoh’s own daughter, raised in Pharaoh’s household, instructed in the wisdom of the Egyptians, and became “mighty in his words and deeds.” Israel was in bondage, but God was already preparing their deliverer. Yet time would reveal that their greatest bondage was not simply being enslaved in Egypt, but remaining enslaved to Egypt in their hearts.

V.23-38

““When he was forty years old, *it came into his heart to visit his brothers, the children of Israel*. And seeing one of them being wronged, **he defended the oppressed man and avenged him by striking down the Egyptian**. *He supposed that his brothers would understand that God was giving them salvation by his hand, but they did not understand*. And on the following day he appeared to them as they were quarreling and **tried to reconcile them**, saying, ‘Men, you are brothers. Why do you wrong each other?’ *But the man who was wronging his neighbor thrust him aside*, saying, ‘**Who made you a ruler and a judge over us?** Do you want to kill me as you killed the Egyptian yesterday?’ At this retort Moses fled and became an exile in the land of Midian, where he became the father of two sons. Now when forty years had passed, **an angel appeared to him in the wilderness of Mount Sinai, in a flame of fire in a bush**. When Moses saw it, he was amazed at the sight, and as he drew near to look, there came the voice of the Lord: ‘I am the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham and of Isaac and of Jacob.’ And Moses trembled and did not dare to look. Then the Lord said to him, ‘Take off the sandals from your feet, for the place where you are standing is holy ground. **I have surely seen the affliction of my people** who are in Egypt, and have **heard their groaning**, and **I have come down to deliver them**. And now come, **I will send you to Egypt**.’ “*This Moses, whom they rejected, saying, ‘Who made you a ruler and a judge?’ — this man God sent as both ruler and redeemer* by the hand of the angel who appeared to him in the bush. This man **led them out, performing wonders and signs** in Egypt and at the Red Sea and in the wilderness for forty years. This is the

BOOK OF ACTS

Moses who **said to the Israelites, 'God will raise up for you a prophet like me from your brothers.'** This is the one who was in the congregation in the wilderness with the angel who spoke to him at Mount Sinai, and with our fathers. **He received living oracles to give to us.**"

2. Rebellion Against the Deliverer

The emphasis Stephen makes in this section is clear: *the very man God sent to deliver Israel was the man Israel rejected.* Verse 25 tells us that they did not understand that "God was giving them salvation by his hand," and instead they "thrust him aside," asking, "*Who made you a ruler and a judge over us?*" But Stephen answers their question in verse 35: **God did.** "*This Moses, whom they rejected... this man God sent as both ruler and redeemer.*" The one they rejected was the very one God had appointed to deliver them from their bondage. And Stephen is showing us that Moses was pointing forward to Jesus. Moses vine said it directly himself, "*God will raise up for you a prophet like me from your brothers*" (Deuteronomy 18:15–19). Like Moses, Jesus was sent by God as a Deliverer, performed signs and wonders, and was rejected by the very people He came to deliver. But why would they reject the one God sent to deliver them? Verse 39 takes us to the heart of the problem.

V.39-43

"Our fathers refused to obey him, but thrust him aside, and in their hearts they turned to Egypt, saying to Aaron, **'Make for us gods who will go before us. As for this Moses who led us out from the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him.'** And they **made a calf** in those days, and **offered a sacrifice to the idol** and were rejoicing in the works of their hands. But God turned away and gave them over to worship the host of heaven, as it is written in the book of the prophets: "'Did you bring to me slain beasts and sacrifices, during the forty years in the wilderness, O house of Israel? You took up the tent of **Moloch** and the star of your god **Rephan**, the images that you made to worship; and I will send you into **exile** beyond Babylon.'"

3. Bondage TO Egypt

Here Stephen finally exposes the heart of the problem. Verse 39 says, "*Our fathers refused to obey him, but thrust him aside, and in their hearts they turned to Egypt.*" Israel had been physically delivered out of Egypt, but **their hearts were still bound to Egypt.** They hated the slavery of Egypt while still loving what Egypt offered them. And notice where that bondage eventually led them. They rejected God's deliverer, turned to other gods, made the golden calf, and "*rejoiced in the works of their hands.*" Eventually their idolatry included Moloch, a false god associated with the horrific sacrifice of children, and Rephan, associated with the worship of stars and celestial bodies. Sin had carried them much further than they probably ever imagined going. This is the danger for us as well. We can want freedom from the consequences of sin while still loving the pleasures of sin. We want freedom from Egypt's chains while continuing to turn toward Egypt in our hearts.

Conclusion:

*****Read 1 Corinthians 10:1-14*****

Paul tells us that these things happened "*as examples for us, that we might not desire evil as they did.*" Israel's greatest problem was not simply that they were slaves in Egypt; it was that **Egypt still had their hearts.** And we face the same danger. We can call ourselves Christians, experience the goodness of God, and yet continue turning our hearts toward the very sins Christ came to deliver us from and thrusting Him aside. We want the deliverance for the consequences of sin but we don't want to submit to the deliverer who offers us that freedom. We don't want submit to Christ or let go of the pleasure of Egypt and therefore stay enslaved within our hearts to it. "For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery." Galatians 5:1 ESV

